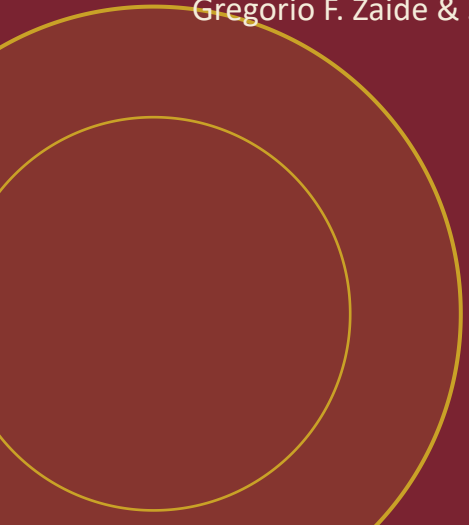
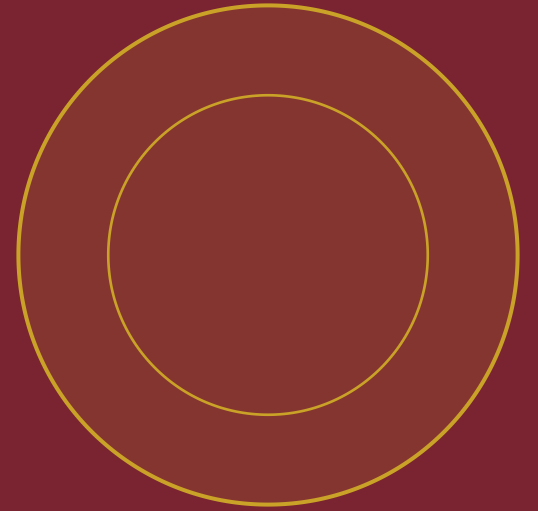


1882 — 1885

SA MAARAW NA ESPANYA

The Secret Mission Behind Rizal's "In Sunny Spain"

Chapter 6 — Jose Rizal: Life, Works, and Writings
Gregorio F. Zaide & Sonia M. Zaide





Four Acts of a Secret Mission



The Secret Mission

Why Rizal left — and why almost
no one was told



The Voyage

Six weeks and five seas from
Manila to Barcelona



Life & Struggle in Madrid

Study, poverty, romance, and
radical company



Reckoning & Triumph

Riots, degrees, and an honest
unfinished ending

Why Leave? The Public Reason

After four years of medicine at the University of Santo Tomas, Rizal had had enough.

He was disillusioned by outdated teaching methods at the Dominican-run university — and by the open prejudice Filipino students faced from their Spanish professors.

So in 1882, he decided to finish his studies in Spain instead.

BUT THIS WASN'T THE WHOLE STORY

Spain, at the time, was a constitutional monarchy that recognized freedom of speech, of the press, and of assembly — rights unavailable back home.

There was one more reason — a bigger one — that Rizal kept out of nearly every biography written in his lifetime.

THE REAL REASON

A Mission Kept Secret — Even From His Mother

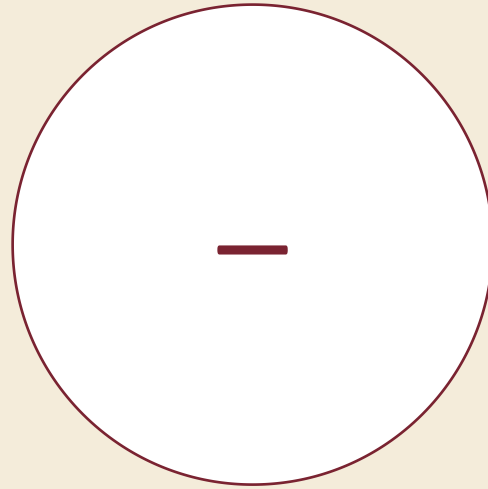
Only Paciano — Rizal's older brother — approved the plan: *a close study of Europe's culture, languages, industries, and laws, in preparation for the larger task of freeing his people from Spanish tyranny.*

“...I cannot excuse myself from this duty, however small it is. I foresee the sacrifices this will demand — but I feel it as an obligation, and I must leave. I will take the risk, and I may succeed or fail ... that is up to God.”

— paraphrased from Rizal's farewell letter to his parents

The Cost at Home

paraphrased from Paciano Rizal's letter, May 20, 1882



When the telegram announcing his departure reached Calamba, *his father, Don Francisco, fell silent — and wept every night*, unable to be consoled by family, doctors, or even strangers.

Paciano quietly arranged for Rizal's expenses to be covered by friends in Manila — so their father's worry, at least, could be gently eased.

Departure in Disguise

May 3, 1882

Rizal boards the Spanish steamer *Salvadora*, bound for Singapore — traveling under a borrowed name.

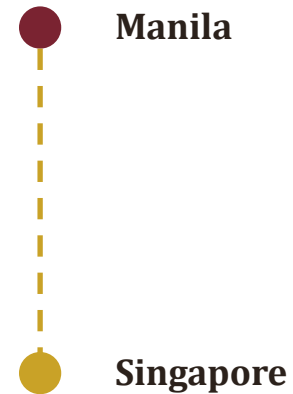
ALIAS USED:

“Jose Mercado”

Only a small circle knew the truth:

- Paciano, his brother
- His uncle Antonio Rivera
- Sisters Neneng & Lucia
- A few trusted friends and Jesuit priests

ROUTE — LEG 1



A sad, quiet farewell — he sketched a last glimpse of Manila's skyline from the departing ship.



Small World at Sea

1

The Lone Filipino

Of sixteen passengers aboard the *Salvadora*, Rizal was the only Filipino — the rest were Spanish, English, and one Black Indian.

2

An Unlikely Ally

Captain Donato Lecha, from Asturias, befriended him — and pushed back when other Spanish passengers made prejudiced remarks about the Philippines.

3

A Sharp Mind at Chess

To pass the time, Rizal played chess with older passengers — and usually won.

Singapore to Suez: A Travelogue of Contrasts

May 8 – 17, 1882



Singapore

Colorful colony — Botanical Garden, temples, two days sightseeing

Point Galle

“Beautiful but lonely and quiet” — his own diary words

Colombo

“More beautiful than Singapore, Point Galle, or Manila”

Suez Canal

Crossed by moonlight — it reminded him of home



Through the Mediterranean to Spain

May 26 – June 16, 1882



Port Said

Naples

Marseille

Barcelona

A crossroads of languages — Arabic, Greek, French, Italian, Spanish, all at once

Bustling commerce, Mount Vesuvius, historic castles

Visited the Chateau d'If — setting of his favorite novel, *The Count of Monte Cristo*

Arrived June 16, 1882 — first impression: unimpressed. That would soon change.

First Ink on Spanish Soil: “Amor Patrio”

Written in liberal, prosperous Barcelona — Rizal's first nationalist essay, published under the pen name Laong Laan, in both Spanish and a Tagalog translation by Marcelo H. del Pilar.

“We who wander in foreign lands offer the first voices to our motherland, veiled in the morning mist — and the stranger the fortune, and the more she suffers on our account, the more deeply she is loved.”

— paraphrased from “Amor Patrio,” *Diariong Tagalog*, August 20, 1882



Settling Into Madrid

Medicine

Universidad Central de Madrid

Philosophy & Letters

Universidad Central de Madrid

Painting & Sculpture

Academy of Fine Arts, San Fernando

Fencing & Shooting

Hall of Arms of Sanz y Carbonell

“A SPARTAN LIFE” — IN RIZAL'S OWN WORDS

He budgeted strictly, spending only on food, clothing, lodging, and books. No gambling, no drinking. His only indulgence: a modest weekly lottery ticket for the Madrid draw.



A Reader's Fortune, A Lover's Restraint

HIS REAL VICE: BOOKS

Rizal spent his savings on secondhand books rather than gambling or courting, as many Filipino students in Madrid did.

His personal library included Voltaire, the Bible, Uncle Tom's Cabin, and The Wandering Jew — the last two, he said, awakened his sense of duty toward his own oppressed people.

Uncle Tom's Cabin • The Wandering Jew • Complete Works of Voltaire • History of the French Revolution

A ROMANCE, DELIBERATELY UNFINISHED

Consuelo Ortiga y Perez, daughter of his host family, fell for Rizal's charm — and he wrote her a poem, “A La Señorita C.O.y.P.,” in August 1883.

But he pulled back before it became serious — out of loyalty to his fiancée, Leonor Rivera, and to his friend Eduardo de Lete, who was himself in love with Consuelo.

Discipline, not indifference — the same restraint that shaped his “Spartan” life in Madrid.

The Poem That Reveals the Cost

“Hinilingan Nila Ako ng Berso” — “They Asked Me for Verses”

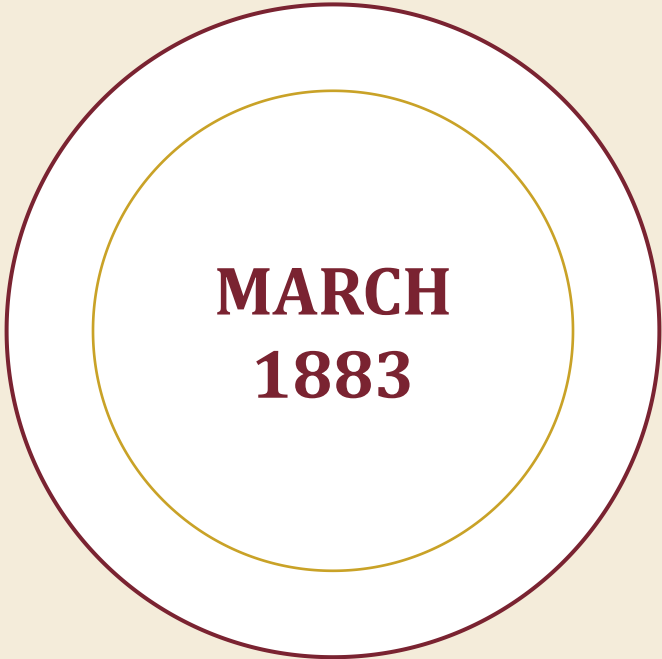
Written for a Filipino New Year's Eve gathering in Madrid, December 31, 1882 — the Circulo Hispano-Filipino asked their gifted young member for a celebratory poem.

What he gave them instead was a lament — a soul too grief-stricken and homesick to sing, its voice trembling like a broken lyre, laughter itself sounding like sorrow.

paraphrased — the mission had a real emotional toll



Joining the Masons — A Strategic Alliance



**MARCH
1883**

Rizal joined the Acacia Lodge of Freemasonry in Madrid — **not out of religious conviction, but as a strategic countermeasure.**

The friars in the Philippines used Catholic religion as a shield to protect their power, wealth, and persecution of nationalist Filipinos. Rizal saw Masonry as the equivalent shield he could use to fight back.

The takeaway: Rizal's political thinking here was tactical, not just idealistic — he picked his tools to fit the fight.



Hunger, Then Honor: June 25, 1884

MORNING

Too poor for breakfast

With his allowance from Calamba delayed again, Rizal went to his university classes on an empty stomach.

He entered a Greek-language contest that day anyway — and won the gold medal.

EVENING

Guest of Honor

That same night, he was the featured speaker at a banquet at Restaurant Inglés, celebrating a double Filipino triumph at the Madrid Exposition of Fine Arts:

Juan Luna — 1st Prize, Spolarium

Félix Hidalgo — 2nd Prize, Christian Virgins Exposed to the Populace

His toast argued genius belongs to no single nation — a pointed rebuke to Spaniards unwilling to accept Filipino talent.

Caught in the Riots

November 20–22, 1884 — Madrid

A professor's speech on academic freedom got him excommunicated by Spanish bishops. Students — Rizal among them — exploded into days of demonstrations.

- Students vowed not to return to class until their demands were met
- The university rector, forced out, escaped through a garden gate to avoid the crowd
- A wealthy banker offered 10,000 duros to bail out arrested students
- Professors publicly sided with their students against the administration
- Rizal, in the middle of it all, wrote home that he escaped uninjured — many Cubans and Spaniards did not



Graduation, With an Honest Asterisk

June 21, 1884

Licentiate in Medicine

Universidad Central de Madrid

June 19, 1885

Licentiate in Philosophy & Letters

His 24th birthday — grade: Sobresaliente (Outstanding)

Two gold medals in Greek language competitions along the way — most of his transcript reads “Sobresaliente.”

THE HONEST ASTERISK

Rizal never received his Doctor of Medicine diploma — he completed the coursework, but never defended a thesis or paid the remaining fees. Even a national hero's record has loose ends.



WHAT'S NEXT

Spain Gave Him the Degrees. What Would Ask More of Him?

Spain gave Rizal his degrees, his readings, his first taste of political danger — but still no comfort, and no finished mission.

Coming next: Chapter 7 — “Paris to Berlin (1885–1887)”